What you cannot always see

A plain-English guide to non-visible disabilities and their everyday impact.

What is a hidden disability?

A hidden disability, also called a non-visible or invisible disability, is one that is not immediately obvious. A person may look well while living with symptoms that affect everyday life. Some people have both visible and non-visible difficulties. People use different words for their experiences; respect the words they prefer.

What can fall under this umbrella?

Examples include disabling chronic pain, fibromyalgia, ME/CFS, some mental health conditions, epilepsy, hearing loss and bowel or bladder conditions. Autism and other lifelong differences can also involve support needs that are not obvious. Not everyone with the same condition has the same difficulties or describes themselves as disabled.

How can it affect daily life?

Depending on the condition, a person may have pain, exhaustion, poor sleep, dizziness, difficulty concentrating, sensory overload or an urgent need for the toilet. Shopping, cooking, travelling, working or socialising may take careful planning. A short outing can use up the energy someone needs for the rest of the day.

Looking well does not show the whole picture

Someone may smile, laugh, dress nicely or enjoy a conversation while struggling. You may see the few minutes they manage in public, but not the rest breaks, help or recovery afterwards. Barriers such as nowhere to sit, inflexible rules and other people's assumptions can make daily life harder.

You do not have to look unwell to deserve understanding and support.

“But you don’t look sick”

When disbelief and judgement become an extra burden.

Comments that can hurt

“You’re just lazy.” “Everyone gets tired.” “Just get on with it.” “You managed it yesterday.” These comments can dismiss difficulties the person is already working hard to manage. Being called a hypochondriac or accused of exaggerating can leave someone feeling ashamed, upset or frightened to ask for help.

Feeling you have to prove yourself

Repeated disbelief can make someone doubt themselves or feel like a fraud, even though their difficulties are real. They may push beyond their limits to avoid criticism, hide how much they are struggling, or withdraw from people. Needing support is nothing to be ashamed of. Nobody should be ridiculed for it.

Seats, queues and everyday assumptions

A person may need a seat on a bus, in a waiting room or while queuing, even if they have no visible walking aid. They may be left standing because others do not recognise their needs, or judged as lazy when they sit down. People can also face suspicious looks or comments when using accessible facilities. Appearance alone does not tell you what support someone needs.

When visible signs change the response

Someone may find their longstanding difficulties are taken more seriously only after they develop a limp or start using a walking aid. The visible change can affect how others respond, but it does not mean the earlier pain, exhaustion or limitations were less real. People deserve to be heard before their difficulties become obvious.

A kinder response

Listen without making the person defend their experience. Ask, “Would a seat help?” or “What would make this easier?” Respect privacy and accept that someone may not want to explain their medical history. Offer help without pressure; the person can tell you whether they want it.

Different days, different needs

Changing ability is part of many conditions. It is not a contradiction.

Good days, bad days and changes within a day

With some disabilities and chronic conditions, symptoms vary. Someone might walk up the road with one stick on one day, need two sticks on another, and be unable to go out on a third. Another person might walk unaided one day and use a wheelchair the next. Support needs can also change within hours.

One moment does not show someone’s limits

Using a wheelchair does not always mean a person cannot stand or walk. They may use it because of pain, fatigue, balance difficulties or limited walking distance. Being able to do something once does not mean they can repeat it safely, comfortably or whenever needed. A better day does not mean their condition has disappeared.

Ways to support someone

Ask what they need today, rather than assuming yesterday's ability still applies. Allow rest breaks, extra time and changes to plans. Accept cancellations without blame. Keep seats and accessible facilities available, and avoid judging people by their age, appearance or whether they use an aid. You may also have non-visible needs yourself; ask staff or others for help where needed.

Words you can use if you want to

“My condition varies. Today I need more support.”
“I can walk a short distance, but I cannot stand for long.”
“You may not be able to see it, but I need to sit down.”
“I would rather not discuss my medical details.”
You can choose how much to explain. Asking for help is not a personal failure.

Believe people. Respect changing needs. Offer understanding without judgement.

Further reading: Scope: Invisible impairments; GOV.UK: DPTAC statement on non-visible disabilities; NHS: Fibromyalgia symptoms. Links checked 24 October 2026.
General awareness information, not individual medical or legal advice.